



Increasing Parent Training through Rapport Building & Difficult Conversations

PRESENTER:

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ABOVE & BEYOND THERAPY



Welcome!

CEU Requirements

Enter your full name + BCBA # in the chat for attendance credit.

Please mute yourself to avoid background noise in the presentation.

Please wait for time for questions or write in chat to avoid delays in finishing the content.

Surveys will be sent after the CEU, which are required to receive your certificate.

AGENDA

- Identify current barriers to parent training
- Identify strategies for addressing barriers
- Understand the importance of rapport in parent training
- Learn practical strategies for building trust with caregivers
- Explore methods to navigate difficult conversations effectively
- Increase caregiver collaboration and engagement



Barriers to Conducting Parent Training

The slide features a white background with two large teal geometric shapes. On the left, a teal triangle points towards the center. On the right, a teal trapezoid is positioned, also pointing towards the center. The text 'Poll the Audience' is centered between these two shapes.

Poll the Audience

Lack of Training or Confidence

- BCBA's feel more confident working directly with clients than coaching adults
- Limited opportunities to practice parent training during coursework or supervision experience
- BCBA's may feel unprepared for resistance or emotional responses from caregivers
- No clear guidance on structure

Time and Caseload Pressures

- High caseloads and productivity demands often prioritize other billable tasks
 - E.g., fitting in all billable supervision hours
 - Limited parent availability; wanting evenings or weekends
 - We tend to “avoid” difficult parents
- Parent training is sometimes undervalued or not adequately scheduled into service models
- Agencies may lack structured systems for consistent parent involvement
- Difficulty demonstrating flexibility and creativity when it comes to fitting in parent training

Discomfort with Difficult Conversations

- Avoidance of confrontation or fear of damaging rapport can prevent BCBA's from addressing sensitive topics (e.g., lack of follow-through).
- BCBA's may struggle to balance being supportive and holding caregivers accountable.

Cultural or Language Barriers

- Differences in values, beliefs, or communication styles can make collaboration more difficult
- Lack of training in culturally responsive care can lead to misunderstanding or mistrust

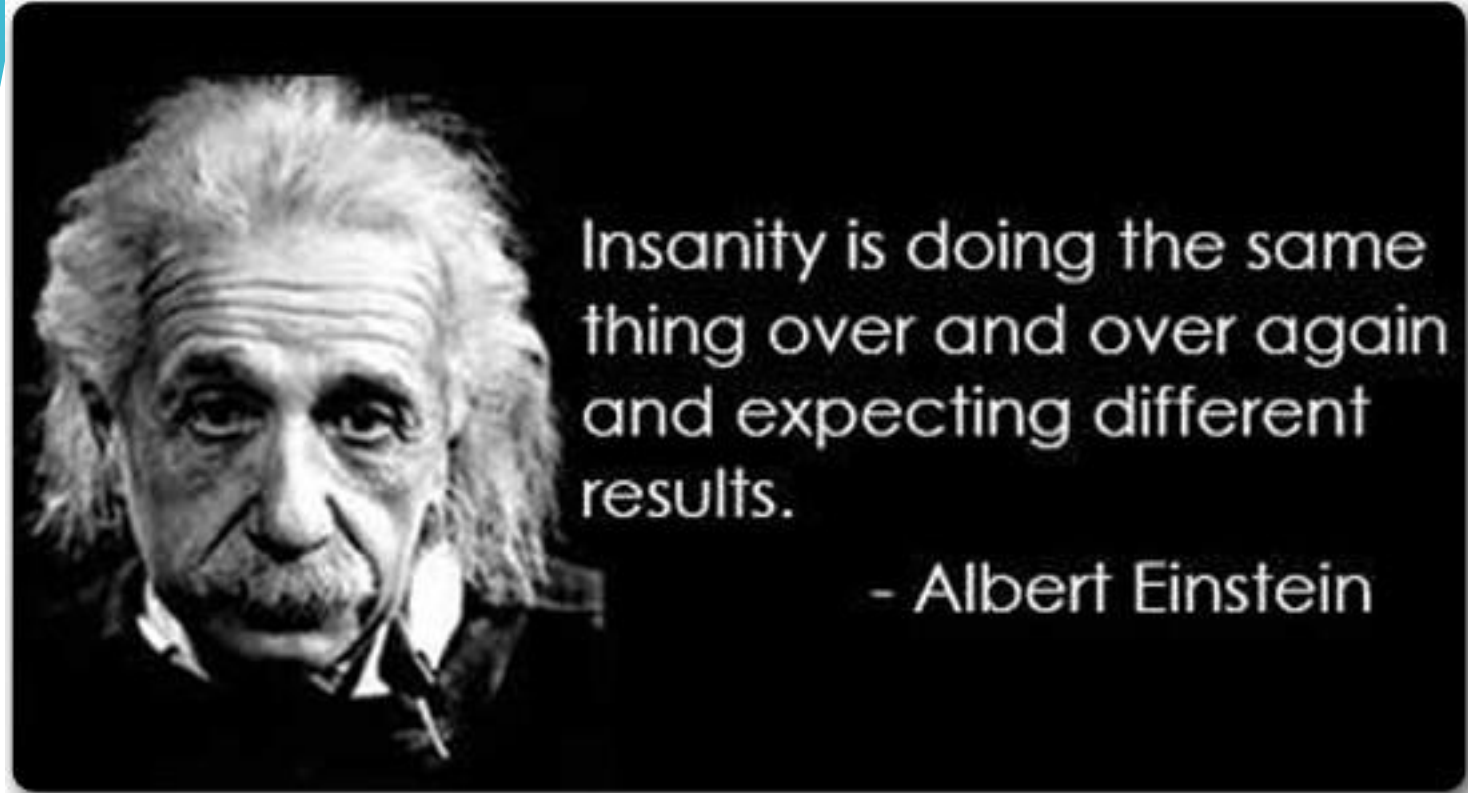
Misunderstanding the Value

- Some BCBAs may overemphasize technician-led intervention, underestimating how critical caregiver involvement is to generalization and long-term success
- Parent training may be viewed as optional rather than essential

Burnout or Compassion Fatigue

- BCBA's experiencing burnout may find parent collaboration emotionally taxing
- Navigating family stress, trauma, or complex dynamics requires energy and emotional resilience
- You have become “the easy button”
- Lack of follow through or change despite repeated attempts at training and feedback

Burnout or Compassion Fatigue





Strategies for Addressing Barriers

Build Skill & Confidence

Barrier: Lack of training or confidence

Solutions:

- Provide regular in-service trainings or CEUs focused on parent training and coaching skills
- Use role-play scenarios during team meetings to practice delivering feedback or navigating resistance
- Share scripts or frameworks (e.g., the 3-part approach: Observation, Impact, Request)
- Get comfortable asking for help

Build Skill & Confidence

- RUBI (“Research Units in Behavioral Intervention”) curriculum
 - Evidence-based
 - Parent workbooks, video vignettes, clinician workbooks
 - 11 “core areas” of behavior basics-ABCs, functions, antecedent interventions, BIPs
 - 7 “supplemental”- toileting, feeding, sleep basics, selective eating
- Key goals:
 - Decrease disruptive behavior
 - Increase adaptive skills
 - Identify functions of behavior
 - Use of social reinforcement for parent-child relationship
 - Use of token economies
 - Appropriate use of planned ignoring, time-out, etc.



Build Skill & Confidence

ABA Visualized

- **Clear, Accessible Learning**
 - Uses simple language and engaging visuals to explain ABA concepts.
 - Breaks down complex strategies into digestible steps for parents of all backgrounds.
- **Focus on Practical Skills**
 - Provides real-world examples and visual guides for daily routines.
 - Helps parents apply ABA strategies like reinforcement, prompting, and behavior shaping in the home.
- **Empowers Caregivers**
 - Builds parent confidence through clear, visual instructions.
 - Encourages active participation and consistency across settings.
- **Ready-to-Use Tools**
 - Includes templates, routines, and visuals parents can implement right away.
 - Supports generalization and maintenance of skills over time.



Make Time & Structure It

Barrier: Time and caseload pressures

Solutions:

- Block off parent training in your schedule as a standing appointment
- Create a standard parent training protocol/checklist so sessions are focused and efficient
- Integrate parent goals into the client's treatment plan to ensure accountability



Strengthen Communication Skills

Barrier: Discomfort with difficult conversations

Solutions:

- Use empathy-driven scripts:
 - “This might be hard to hear, but I’m sharing it because I care about your child’s progress.”
- Frame challenges around shared goals:
 - “We both want what’s best for your child, so let’s figure this out together.”
- Offer parent handouts or visuals to make difficult topics more digestible
- Read the room and pace your feedback
- Keep an open mind and be flexible
 - Always ready to pivot

Promote Cultural Responsiveness

Barrier: Cultural or language differences

Solutions:

- Ask families about their values, routines, and preferences early in the intake process.
- Translate materials or use interpreters when needed.
- Practice cultural humility: Ask rather than assume; adapt recommendations to fit their context.



Reframe the Value of Parent Training

Barrier: Misunderstanding its importance

Solutions:

- Use data to show how generalization and progress improve with caregiver involvement.
- Share stories or case studies where parent training made a measurable impact.
- Frame parent training as a **treatment component**, not an optional add-on.



Prevent & Address Burnout

Barrier: Compassion fatigue or burnout

Solutions:

- Normalize the emotional demands of working with families—offer peer support or supervision groups.
- Encourage boundaries and breaks between emotionally intense sessions.
- Acknowledge staff efforts in difficult family situations to build morale.



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Building Rapport

Why Rapport Matters

- Trust is the foundation of collaboration
- Strong rapport increases caregiver engagement and follow-through
- Decreases resistance to feedback or behavior change recommendations
- Promotes generalization and maintenance of skills

Barriers to Building Rapport

- Cultural or language differences
- Previous negative experiences with professionals
- Caregiver stress and burnout
- Misalignment of goals between caregivers and clinicians

Strategies to Build Rapport

- Practice active listening and empathy
- Validate caregiver experiences
- Use non-technical, respectful language
- Start sessions with personal connection ("How's your day?")
- Celebrate small wins together

Building Rapport Without Oversharing

- Be warm, consistent, and genuinely interested
- Ask open-ended questions about the caregiver's experience
- Share relatable (but appropriate) examples of similar challenges
- Use humor carefully—make the family the hero, not yourself
- Maintain professional boundaries: focus on the client and family's needs



Effective Communication & Difficult Conversations

Elements of Effective Communication

- Clear, jargon-free explanations
- Consistent, respectful tone
- Use visuals or modeling when possible
- Check for understanding (“Can you show me how you’d do that?”)
- Provide choices and collaborative problem-solving
- Don’t listen with the intent of responding

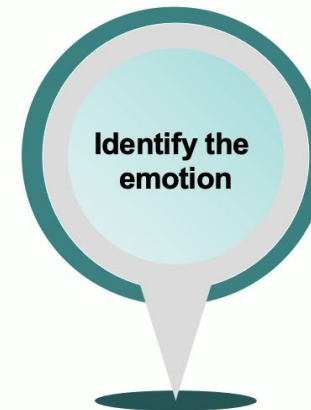


Elements of Effective Communication

Active Listening



Give your **attention**
Clear your **thoughts**



Look for **true meaning**
Say it **out loud**



Paraphrase
Repeat **key words**

Validating someone's perspective doesn't mean agreeing with it,
it means expressing that you understand that they feel that way.

Set Clear Expectations

Elements of Effective Communication



Introducing Difficult Conversations

- Prepare in advance with data and empathy
- Consider timing and setting
- Use a strengths-based approach
- Set clear intentions: “I want to partner with you to help your child succeed.”

Framework for Difficult Conversations

- **The 3-Part Approach:**
- **Observation:** “I’ve noticed...”
- **Impact:** “This affects...”
- **Request or Goal:** “Would you be open to...”
- Always offer support and next steps

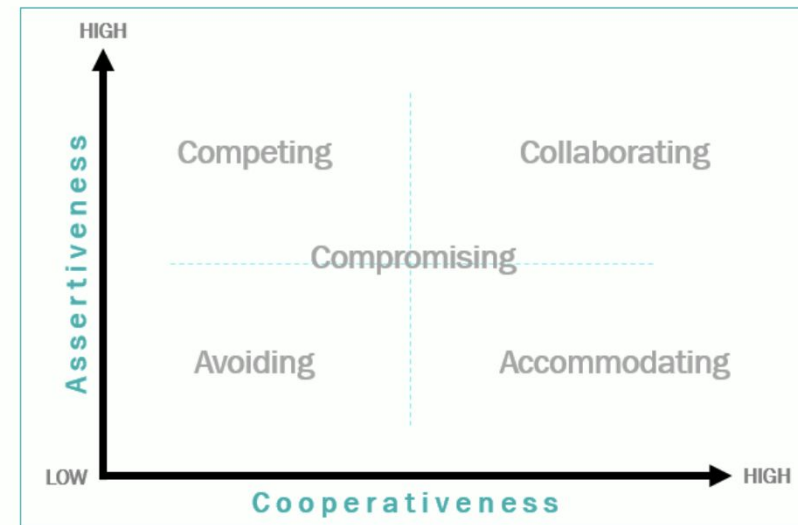
Framework for Difficult Conversations

The Ask-First Model

- 1 Ask for their opinion of their own performance
- 2 Agree or disagree and provide your behavioral assessment
- 3 Ask for their opinion on a solution
- 4 Agree or disagree and provide your recommendation
- 5 Agree on plan of action/date
- 6 Ask how you can support them

Framework for Difficult Conversations

What to Consider When Choosing a Conflict Mode



TIME • ISSUE • RELATIONSHIP

Framework for Difficult Conversations

Share Your Facts

- I saw...
- I heard...
- I noticed...

Tell Your Story

- I am starting to think
- It seems to me that...
- I am wondering if...

Our stories create
our emotions

Ask others for their views

- What am I missing?
- Can you help me understand?
- What happened?

Framework for Difficult Conversations

Talk Tentatively

- In my opinion...
- Maybe it would make more sense if...
- I believe what we should do is...

Encourage Testing

- How does this look/sound from your perspective?
- If you see it differently, I would love to hear your view

Ways to Promote Active Engagement in training

- **Talk through 'role-play' with a parent without the child present**
 - Help them identify ABCs without judgement
 - Make a plan to implement an intervention during next live training
- **Alternate active and passive training modalities**
 - Create a schedule for narrative, discussion-based trainings, alternate with in-vivo practices to decrease reactivity and stress
 - Identify and discuss goals for each session ahead of the meeting
 - Start with parent choice
 - Create if-then visuals with scripts (keep on fridge) for problem bx
- **Offer scheduling alternatives**
 - Lunch break discussions
 - Morning, evening commute discussions (alternate with live training)
 - narrative ABC data
 - Coffee break discussions



Tips for Caregiver Involvement

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- Caregivers can observe therapy sessions
- Caregivers can be assigned session-appropriate tasks (data collection, IOA, delivery of reinforcement, social goals, prompting functional communication, etc.)
- Caregivers can take data outside of therapy session to review with BCBA
- Caregivers can review ABA materials to better understand principles
- Caregivers can engage in weekly parent training



Types of Sessions

- Reviewing documents (e.g., authorization documents, assessment, progress reports, etc.,)
- Central Reach review of programs and graphs
- Coordination of care (e.g., medical, school, or other outside therapies.)
- Community outings (e.g., grocery store, social settings, etc.,)
- Observing therapy session while discussing techniques used
- Role playing different techniques
- Caregiver demonstrating skills with client
- Reviewing BIPs

**check funder-specific requirements before billing*





Tips for Practicing Compassionate Care

Tips for Practicing Compassionate Care

Taylor et al., (2018) defined compassion care as:

"The recognition, empathic understanding of and emotional resonance with the concerns, pain, distress or suffering of others coupled with motivation and relational action to ameliorate these conditions."

Strategies to support compassionate care in our practice as BCBA's:

- Avoiding passing judgement and blame
- Avoiding trigger words
- Viewing the entire family as a client
- Utilizing empathy and perspective taking
- Recognizing parents' efforts and dedication to their child's treatment

Tips for Practicing Compassionate Care

Remember: “ABA” and “ASD” might be new terms

- There may be resistance to the diagnosis
- Allow processing time
- Letting go of their “plan”
- Looking for a cause to blame
- Anger, denial
- Comparing to other children
- Re-learning everything
 - “This worked for my other kids”
- Advice “burnout”

Tips for Practicing Compassionate Care

How can the BCBA Help?

- One step a time
- Be supportive
- Build rapport and trust
- Switch focus from diagnosis to treatment
- Slowly work up to full recommended hours
- Don't immediately focus on "what they're doing wrong"
- Demonstrate patience
- Be careful with terminology
- Read the room
- Provide research or supplemental materials
- Shaping and reinforcement
- Demonstrate reliability and consistency



Tips for Prioritizing Goals

- Introduction to ASD and ABA
- Functional Communication Training
 - Echoic, PECS, Single word or sound mands
- Providing positive reinforcement
 - Train on importance of reinforcement over punishment
- Behavior Intervention Plan
 - Target behaviors for reduction
 - Replacement behaviors
 - Functions of Behavior
 - Antecedent modifications
 - Consequence Modifications
- Maintenance & Generalization of ABA programs



How to “Read the Room”

Read Between The Lines

- “I really just want my child to talk...”
 - BCBA should train on:
 - Preference assessments/identifying reinforcers
 - Providing positive reinforcement
 - Shaping attempts
 - Functional Communication Training (FCT)
 - Echoics
 - PECS or AAC
 - Single-word requests
 - Signs
 - Gestures
- Determine most appropriate method for client
- Consistency is key



Read Between The Lines

- “He’s out of control. I can’t take him anywhere”
 - BCBA should train on:
 - Is it age-appropriate?
 - Setting realistic goals with the family
 - Functions of behavior
 - Preference assessments/identifying reinforcers
 - Providing positive reinforcement
 - Identify triggers in the environment
 - Replacement behaviors
 - Prompting
 - Shaping responses
 - Antecedent & Consequence modifications
 - How to end on success
 - Avoiding power struggles

Read Between The Lines

- “We’re all just exhausted....”
 - BCBA should train on:
 - Not allowing the fear of the challenging behavior to control the household
 - Schedule/routine
 - Power struggles
 - One goal at a time
 - Antecedent modifications to help throughout the day
 - Local resources (varies by state)
 - Respite care
 - Parent-led support groups
 - Transportation services
 - Recognizing and celebrating all the little wins



Read Between The Lines

- "I don't like this. It's too hard for her.."
- BCBA should train on:
 - Increasing support to gain trust and buy in
 - Slow down
 - Pairing
 - Rapport building
 - Show the family it works
 - graphs of progress made
 - demonstrate progress directly with client
 - provide research
 - Review goals and re-prioritize if needed

Tips for Success

- SMART goals are for parents too!
- Most impactful to client's learning & independence
- Limit number of open goals at one time to 4-5 max
- Follow funder-specific requirements
- Be aware of pre-requisites needed first
- Be realistic with goals, timelines, and steps to success
- Age-appropriate
- Realistic for current amount of hours
- Realistic for what family is willing to generalize and work on outside of therapy
- Tracking progress should be realistic for family



Case Study for Participation

- Scenario: Parent not following behavior plan
- Practice: Use 3-Part Approach to address non-adherence
- Debrief: What worked? What could be improved?

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Final Takeaways

- Rapport is not optional—it's essential
- Address challenges with empathy and data
- Training is a two-way street—collaborate, don't dictate
- Ongoing communication = better outcomes for the family and the client
- Humility goes a long way
 - Never be the smartest person in the room



Resources

Koegel, R. L., Bimbela, A., & Schreibman, L. (1996). Collateral effects of parent training on family interactions. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 26(3), 347– 359. <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF02172479>.

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Questions???

Reminder: CEU certificates will go out AFTER completion of the survey. Surveys will be sent out within 24-48 business hours post-CEU.